

The Fix: *Have Only as Many as You Can Afford*

I'll say this until I'm blue in the face: *there is no need to enter into a marriage contract if you don't want kids*. If this describes you, you'll probably want to skip over the next few chapters of this book because the information won't apply. But if you're like most people I know, your family dynasty is going to include one or more children. The question then becomes: How many should you have?

You may not like the answer, but here it is: *have only as many children as your income can support*. Nobody wants to be told how many kids they should or shouldn't have. And yet those same people often come to me, wanting my advice on how to raise healthy, brilliant children into a world of opportunity that simply doesn't exist unless you, the parents, create it. "But Kevin," they say, "there is no greater joy than children." I agree. Which is why you deserve to give the ones you've got the absolute best shot at life. In today's world, having a whole bunch of kids may not be realistic; moreover, it may not be fair because it overtaxes your family's resources. You must balance the joys of having multiple children with the fact that those children could be living close to the poverty line as a result of your decisions.

People tend to think of children outside of the metrics of money. Most prospective parents don't take a realistic look at their budget and decide, "Yes, let's have a third child" or "You know what? Let's not." For parents who actually choose to have children, who plan to have them, this decision usually comes from an emotional place. But what I am suggesting is having at least a few thoughts where you *separate the decision to have children from the emotional need to have children*. At least try to think logically about your finances instead of just heading blindly toward dividing the family's resources between more and more mouths. The more children you have, the less they have—the less money, possibly less experiences and advantages, maybe even fewer educational opportunities. And, let's not forget: more children means less of your time, because you're busy with all the other kids and the multiple jobs you're juggling to try to keep